

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Johnson: ‘I’ve done my part’ on Bears

Mayor ready to punt as team shifts stadium focus back to Arlington Heights

By Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson said Tuesday he has done everything he can to lobby lawmakers to come up with state money to keep the Bears in Chicago, even as the team now looks toward Arlington Heights instead.

Following Tribune reporting last week that the team is pivoting its focus back to Arlington Heights and away from the city’s lakefront, Johnson told reporters Tuesday that “there’s a long way to go still” — but hinted that he won’t be an active player in this next round of talks with state lawmakers.

Asked whether he plans to lobby Springfield’s Chicago delegation against any legislation the Bears may seek for a new stadium development in the suburbs, the mayor said “That’s a decision that they’ll have to make.”

“I’ve done everything that I possibly could do,” Johnson said at his weekly City Hall news conference. “I’ve done my part. You know, at this point, if the state of Illinois wants to keep the Bears in the city of Chicago ... the ball is on (their) side of the field.”

The Bears confirmed to the Tribune on Friday its shift toward an Arlington Heights stadium, which would depend on a legislative package in Springfield to allow for negotiated financing of large-scale developments.

It was the latest twist in the NFL franchise’s yearslong saga over whether they will indeed leave the city, where for the past year the mayor has advocated for a new lakefront stadium to keep them here — to some displeasure from his progressive base.

Two weeks ago, Bears

Turn to Johnson, Page 11



A'mayra Prince, 6, tells Chicago HOPES for Kids Development Manager Alex Granato dressed as Supergirl, about her adventure riding the carousel during a Thursday field trip to Lincoln Park Zoo for families who experience homelessness and housing insecurity. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

AmeriCorps cuts leave kids programs in limbo

Some summer programming shuttered or left scrambling for volunteers

By Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

In the shadow of the carousel at an otherwise empty Lincoln Park Zoo, a crowd of children rushing ahead of their families shrieked as they saw two grown-ups dressed as Superman and Supergirl.

The superheroes’ sighting checked off a scavenger hunt box on an evening when the zoo was closed to everyone except the hundreds of families served by Chicago HOPES for Kids,

a nonprofit organization that provides academic support to children experiencing homelessness and housing insecurity.

Outings like the trip to the zoo are one of many opportunities that Chicago HOPES offers to the disadvantaged kids it serves. But those large field trips require dozens of chaperones and are one of the likely casualties this summer of federal budget cuts to AmeriCorps, whose members are a crucial part of the operation, HOPES Program Director Dajuan King said.

“No way around it — our program, at least half our staffing model is AmeriCorps,” King said during last week’s zoo visit, as a late spring thunderstorm approached overhead. “It’s really limiting how many families we can serve.”

AmeriCorps members are typically college students or recent graduates who are paired with service programs across the country and receive a stipend and an educational award for loans or tuition. It’s one of the many federal agencies to suffer massive

funding cuts and program terminations as President Donald Trump’s administration seeks to reduce government spending.

The Trump administration in April eliminated state-administered grants for 28 AmeriCorps programs in Illinois, affecting more than 630 members statewide, according to a lawsuit filed by Illinois Attorney General Kwame Raoul, 23 other states and the District of Columbia.

The sprawling programming

Turn to AmeriCorps, Page 4



Peter Isely, one of the founders of the Survivors Network of those Abused by Priests and a survivor of sexual abuse by a priest, speaks during a news conference Tuesday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Pope failed to ‘properly investigate’ child sex abuse, victims group alleges

By Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

A group representing victims sexually abused by Catholic priests alleged on Tuesday Pope Leo XIV has exhibited a “pattern of failure to properly investigate abuse claims,” including allegations that the Chicago-born pontiff mishandled multiple cases while in prominent leadership roles in the city.

“It was his responsibility to follow the meager church protocols and laws put in place,” said James Egan, a spokesperson for the Survivors Network of those Abused by Priests, at a news conference. “Given his record, it doesn’t seem that (he) prioritized protecting children at all.”

A longtime missionary, Pope Leo XIV was born Robert Prevost in 1955 at Mercy Hospital in Chicago, and grew up

in south suburban Dolton. Prevost, the first American pope, was largely welcomed with open arms across the city, and described as someone who “cared for people.”

He called for environmental stewardship and caring for the poor in his inaugural Mass.

SNAP, however, said it wants to bring light to the “under-

Turn to SNAP, Page 11

GEORGE WENDT 1948-2025

From Second City troupe to fame on TV’s ‘Cheers’

The actor and South Side native died early Tuesday. He was 76

By Bob Goldsborough
Chicago Tribune

George Wendt, the actor and comedian who cut his teeth at Chicago’s improvisational comedy troupe Second City before finding fame as part of the ensemble cast of the beloved 1980s NBC sitcom “Cheers,” has died. He was 76.

A native of the South Side neighborhood of Beverly, Wendt died early Tuesday at home. A resident of Los Angeles’ Studio City area since buying a home there in 1985, Wendt had been in declining health in recent years, though no cause of death was given. His death was confirmed by his publicist.

On “Cheers,” Wendt played the affable, heavyset barfly Norm Peterson, frequently holding a mug of beer in one hand and delivering a self-deprecating quip.

Those who knew Wendt personally could attest to his unassuming, approachable manner, and the fact that an actor with such tremendous Hollywood success never allowed stardom to go to his head. Instead, Wendt endeared himself to fans both onstage in TV, films and stage productions and also offstage — particularly in his native



Actor George Wendt speaks during an interview Aug. 19, 2019, outside Soldier Field in Chicago. **ERIN HOOLEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Chicago — as a down-to-Earth, sports-loving guy always quick with wry, Norm-ish observations and a perpetual insistence that his writers were the ones doing the real work.

Another of Wendt’s celebrated comedic roles — as the uber-Chicago Bears nut “Superfan” Bob Swerski in the early-1990s “Saturday Night Live” sketch “Superfans” — broadened his fan base even further, particularly locally. Wendt’s portrayal of Swerski’s confidence in the Bears’ prospects — never offensive, and

Turn to Wendt, Page 2

Beautifully reimagined

Parachute HiFi brings creative Korean American food and cocktails with simplified style to Chicago. **Food & Health**

Trump pushes agenda on Hill

The president implores House Republicans to pass the budget bill, but dissent persists. **Nation & World**

Oblique injury sidelines pitcher

The Cubs put reliever Porter Hodge on the injured list, creating another challenge for bullpen. **Chicago Sports**

TODAY’S WEATHER



High **53** Low **47**

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 16

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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